accepted by the general community of nations as defining their rights and the means of procedure by which those rights may be protected or violations of them redressed".

According to Starke[6] "International law may be defined as that body of law which is composed for its greater part of the principles and rules of conduct which states feel themselves bound to observe, and therefore, do commonly observe in their relations with each other…".

Sources of International Law

The material sources of international law fall into five principal categories: These are now briefly dealt with.

1. *Custom:* Customs and usages over a long period of time have come to acquire legal validity with their recognition by the international community. In the *Paqueta Habana* (175 US 677 1900), the US Supreme Court upheld the validity of customary international law. Though the preponderance of traditional customary laws has declined due to the conclusion of a large number of law-making treaties, for example, the Vienna Conventions of 18 April 1961, of 24 April 1963 and 22 May 1969 on Diplomatic Relations, Consular Relations, and the Law of Treaties, respectively, scholars still acknowledge the significant role played by international customs.

2. *Treaties:* Even before Grotius codified international law, treaties existed as a source of international law since the written records of man. Treaties are binding on states who are parties to them and are under the obligation to respect the terms contained therein. A treaty can be

(a) law making, laying down the rules of universal or general applications such as the Covenant of the League of Nations and the Charter of the United Nations; or

(b) contracts between two or only a few states concerning a specific matter involving these states exclusively.

3. *Decisions of Judicial or Arbitral Tribunals:* International judicial decisions of International Court of Justice and its predecessor, the Permanent Court of International Justice, are important sources of international law. The advisory opinions of both these Courts